

WASHINGTON

Calling Card

Overenthusiastic pundits were having a field day speculating when Prime Minister Manmohan Singh did not figure on the list of big, small and peripheral world leaders who spoke to US President-elect Barack Obama. But the truth was that the schedule originally suggested by Washington did not fit into Manmohan's schedule as he was travelling to the Gulf countries. The call from Washington finally came on November 12; Obama told him that he was looking forward to visit India. Manmohan is usually generous with his compliments—his last one for US President George Bush was that India loved him—though they may not be backed by reality. In the case of Obama, however, India is looking towards him with high hope. *by Saurabh Shukla*



OBAMA FINALLY SPOKE
TO MANMOHAN

AFP

Royal Loss

Even the Queen was not left unharmed. In the global economic meltdown that dug deep into the pockets of the rich and famous, Great Britain's Queen Elizabeth II lost £25 million.



THE MALDIVES
FEEL THE HEAT

MALDIVES | Land Ahoy

The newly-elected president of the Maldives, Mohamed Nasheed, plans to set aside a part of the island nation's billion-dollar income from tourism to lease land for its 3 lakh inhabitants. The 1,192 coral islands that comprise the Maldives are under threat from global warming. The islands are just 1.5 m above sea level. The UN predicts that the sea is likely to rise by up to 59 cm by 2100, drowning this smallest Asian country. Nasheed is looking at India and Sri Lanka for land as they share a similar culture, and also at Australia for its climate. The Maldives has the lowest high point in the world, making it more susceptible to the sea. Nasheed won the Maldives's first democratic presidential election in October. His country is in the midst of a severe economic crisis. *by Saurabh Shukla*

THE SHOURYA FEATURES A HIGHLY MANOEUVRABLE RE-ENTRY VEHICLE MEANT TO DEFEAT ANTI-MISSILE DEFENCES.

DELHI | Rocket Signs

THE DRDO'S LATEST strategic ballistic missile, the 600-km range Shourya, may well be another deterrent for India's neighbours. The land-based variant of the enigmatic K-15 submarine-launched ballistic missile was test-fired from Balasore on November 12. It is the first new strategic missile developed by



THE SHOURYA

the DRDO since the 700-km Agni-1 was tested in 2002. The solid-fuelled Shourya may replace all three variants of the Prithvi series missiles operated by the army and air force. Unlike the cumbersome liquid-fuelled Prithvi missiles which have to be fuelled and prepared before launch, the Shourya is a canisterised missile, which can be easily handled and transported.

by Sandeep Unnithan